

Israel says it will take Gaza City ‘quickly’

Netanyahu’s vow comes as a targeted IDF strike leaves 6 journalists dead

BY LIOR SOROKA, HAZEM BALOUSHA AND SIHAM SHAMALAKH

TEL AVIV — Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu defended his plans to take over key areas of the Gaza Strip, saying Israel would move “quickly” to evacuate and then seize Gaza City, where doctors and journalists said late Sunday that an Israeli strike targeted and killed six journalists, including two correspondents for Al Jazeera’s Arabic-language news channel.

The strike, which hit just before midnight, struck a tent housing the journalists outside the gate of al-Shifa Hospital, according to the facility’s director, Mohamed Abu Salmiya. It came several hours after Netanyahu, at a news conference in Jerusalem, told reporters that Israel would begin its operation “by first enabling the civilian population to safely leave the combat areas to designated safe zones.”

Abu Salmiya said two prominent reporters — Anas al-Sharif, 28, and Mohammed Qureiq, 31 — were among the dead. Two Al Jazeera cameramen, Ibrahim Thaher and Mohammed Noufal, were also killed, according to the network.

The Israeli military issued a statement confirming the strike and accused Sharif of serving as the head of a Hamas “terrorist cell.” Sharif had reported from northern Gaza for the network for

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Shootings: Doctors tell of attacks on Gazans seeking food aid. A6



LORENZO TUGNOLI/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Bedouin residents of Sweida, Syria, join an evacuation convoy while Druze militants secure the area last month.

Bloodshed in Syria reveals its fragility

BY KAREEM FAHIM AND ZAKARIA ZAKARIA

SWEIDA, SYRIA — Charred bodies sat in an awful heap on a city sidewalk. Blood mixed with dirt in a traffic circle where civilians were gunned down. Grieving women clasped arms on Sweida’s stricken streets, wearing black.

This was the aftermath of the brutal violence that seized the Sweida area in mid-July, among the deadliest in Syria since rebels toppled Bashar al-Assad’s dictatorship last year. In a fight charged by sectarian rage, more than 1,000 people were killed as gunmen battled for days, according to human rights groups.

Weeks later, the conflict still

Tensions still simmer weeks after sectarian violence killed hundreds

simmers, with government forces surrounding the city of Sweida in a standoff with Druze fighters within. The carnage has polarized Syria, sparking protests by members of the Druze religious minority, counter-demonstrations by government supporters, accusations of treachery and vows of revenge.

“They killed, and we killed,” said Saud al-Wadi, 58, a Bedouin who fled the violence with his

family, speaking of his former Druze neighbors. “There is blood between us.”

The two sides battled again briefly on Aug. 3, along several front lines. Inside the city, the mainly Druze residents who remain are running low on water, fuel and other essentials. Stranded in the no-man’s-land between the forces are perhaps hundreds of uncollected bodies, rescue workers say.

Nearly a week of intense fighting in the city, in southwest Syria, was set off by the kidnapping of a Druze merchant and retaliatory abductions of Sunni Muslim Bedouins, residents said. The communities have clashed in the past, including over land.

The ferocity of the dispute this time delivered a warning about the fragility of Syria’s social fabric. And the authorities’ failure to quiet the confrontation is highlighting the struggles of President Ahmed al-Sharaa’s young government in responding to tensions or outbreaks of violence — without making them worse.

Sweida’s descent was marked by atrocities and summary killings, heavy-weapons fire and airstrikes. Buildings throughout the city were looted. Villages beyond it were emptied and burned. Nearly 200,000 people have been displaced, according to the United Nations. Scores remain missing.

SEE SYRIA ON A7

Russians see Alaska summit as early win

Meeting comes with Putin having made no clear concessions on war

BY FRANCESCA EBEL AND CATHERINE BELTON

MOSCOW — Russian officials and commentators crowded about landing a summit between President Vladimir Putin and President Donald Trump on Friday in Alaska, the first time the Russian leader has been invited to the United States outside the United Nations since 2007 — and apparently without the Kremlin having made any clear concessions over its war in Ukraine.

European and Ukrainian officials, meanwhile, scrambled to respond to the administration’s sudden reversal. Days before announcing the summit Friday, Trump was expressing frustration over Putin’s continued bom-

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Peace talks: White House is open to a trilateral meeting. A9

Trump’s Ukraine shifts: How his position has evolved, in quotes. A10



JAY PICKTHORN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Jen Phelan, right, and her daughter hug a well-wisher after becoming emotional at the Phelan family’s farewell party at XIX Brewing Company in Vermillion, South Dakota, on Aug. 1.

Closing the books after a bathroom bill’s passage

A family found community in a S.D. town but left amid concerns for their transgender daughter

BY CASEY PARKS

VERMILLION, S.D. — Their time in this small Midwestern town was nearly over, but for now, Mike Phelan still had a business to run, so he and his daughter leashed their dog and headed up the street.

The commute took three minutes. The Phelans passed sprawling Victorian houses with wrap-around porches, then Mike pulled out his keys. When they moved here from Chicago five years ago, Mike discovered Vermillion had a university, locally made bread Oprah Magazine once declared the best in the world, and an author who’d won the National Book Award. But

Vermillion didn’t have a bookstore. No university town should exist without a place to buy novels and new nonfiction, Mike thought, so he’d opened one and named it “Outside of a Dog” after a Groucho Marx quote — “Outside of a dog, a book is man’s best friend.”

Mike twisted the key and looked down Main Street. Nearly all of downtown’s quaint brick storefronts had Pride flags in their windows. He’d once dreaded moving to a red state, but Vermillion had surprised him. He wanted to stay here for the rest of his life. But in the morning, his wife and son would head east with a trailer, and soon, Mike and

SEE BOOKSTORE ON A14

Trump rushes to build White House ballroom, but review could take years

BY JONATHAN EDWARDS

President Donald Trump is rushing to break ground next month on a giant White House ballroom but has not yet submitted the project for a review that experts said is required by law and often takes years to complete.

A security fence and a tennis

pavilion — neither of which involved the White House itself — each took at least two years to move through the National Capital Planning Commission, which vets construction of and renovation to the region’s federal buildings. The Trump administration plans to start work next month on a \$200 million, 90,000-square-foot structure that would nearly

double the footprint of the main building and its East and West wings.

Records show the project has yet to be reviewed by the commission. Three former planning commission members told The Washington Post that a review of any exterior construction project at the White House is required by federal law.

“If we had jurisdictional review over a fence, we would logically have jurisdiction over an entire wing being added to the White House,” said L. Preston Bryant Jr., who chaired the commission for nearly a decade before stepping down in 2019.

At first, Trump administration officials said a 1964 executive order allows the president to

bypass the commission. But after a Post reporter pointed out the legal requirement, officials said the commission “will be a part of that process at the appropriate time.”

Since taking office in January, Trump has overseen myriad interior design retouches and vowed to replace a “terribly” remodeled

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IN THE NEWS

Redistricting fight Texas Gov. Greg Abbott threatened to call more special sessions until Democrats return to the state. A3

Regression to the mean? Many NFL observers say the Commanders are due to backslide, but quarterback Jayden Daniels might not allow it, Jason La Canfora writes. C1

THE NATION A border wall expansion might mean the end of jaguars wandering into southern Arizona from Mexico. A2
A former police dog is sniffing out threats to bee colonies. A2

THE ECONOMY Volunteers are combating “AI slop” finding its way onto Wikipedia. A11
STYLE Gen Zers love location sharing. They’re unsure about the new Instagram Map. B1

Watching an R-rated film on a flight is okay, as long as you follow certain protocols. B1

SPORTS The Nationals have traditionally been less active than most teams in picking players off the waiver wire, but that’s changing. C1

THE REGION Statues of Confederate soldiers that once stood in Richmond are headed for a museum in Los Angeles. C7
The Trump administration’s immigration crackdown has some Haitians on Maryland’s Eastern Shore worried for their community. C7

DNA evidence helped identify the body of a boy found dead in Virginia in 1972, but authorities still don’t know who killed him. C7

HEALTH & SCIENCE A bat flying into her mouth was just the start of problems for a woman without insurance. D1

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